

myself through the lens of the very microscope I was directing at extreme couponers.

Just who are the extreme couponers? That is the question I asked when I began the book, hoping to have a specific profile of the avid couponer by the time I'd completed it. I shudder to think that viewers of the TLC's *Extreme Couponing* television program might believe they've viewed the typical couponer. The premiere episode featured four coupon-obsessed savers who were challenged to get as much merchandise as they could for as little as possible.

I should have known that a reality program would portray the extreme couponer in an unflattering light. Amanda was presented as a hoarder who had enough toilet paper in her stockpile to last her and her husband forty years. Despite his protests, her two rooms full of stockpiled groceries were spilling into a third room, her husband's "man cave." Nathan Engles, also known as "Mr. Coupon" online and among friends, had 1500 sticks of deodorant stockpiled in his garage. "The Krazy Coupon Lady," Joanie Diemer, was shown pilfering for coupons in a dumpster alongside her four-year-old son. Neither Nathan nor Joanie's regular donations to food banks was mentioned, though later programs would focus on some of the donations. Viewers would be bored with my minimal stockpiles, though my double coupon opportunities might have merited a few "oohs and ahhs" from someone who'd never experienced such a trip of their own. I know I impress some of my workshop attendees with the slides I show of those big hauls in my power point presentation.